

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Amos

Amos

Amos spoke to people who worshiped idols. He said, “prepare to meet your God” (Amos 4:12). He also warned the rich people who treated the poor unfairly. He said that justice should flow “like an ever-flowing stream” (5:24).

Why did this shepherd from Tekoa go to Bethel to speak such strong words of judgment? Amos was not a prophet by trade (7:14). God called him to speak. Amos describes God’s voice as a “roar” (1:2; 3:8). Amos’s message joins two things that belong together: right worship and right action toward others. God’s people still need Amos’s help to see this connection.

Setting

In 931 BC, the kingdom of Israel divided into two kingdoms. The northern kingdom kept the name Israel. The southern kingdom was called Judah.

Jeroboam I was the first king of the northern kingdom. He did not want his people to go south to Jerusalem to worship. So he built places of worship at Dan and Bethel. He used images of young bulls to represent the Lord. This was like what Israel had done earlier at Mount Sinai (Exodus 32; 1 Kings 12:25–33).

This choice showed that the northern kingdom had rejected God’s word. They no longer let God shape their worship or their way of life. Over time, Israel’s worship became like the worship of other nations. Israel also began to mistreat weak and poor people.

Jeroboam I built places of worship with calf images at Dan and Bethel (1 Kings 12:29). The northern kingdom also worshiped the baals. The baals were local forms of the Canaanite storm god.

Because of this, worship of Yahweh, the Lord, became mixed with the religion of Israel’s neighbors. Many Israelites still worshiped Yahweh. But they also worshiped local gods. They thought these gods could give them what they wanted, such as rain or fertile land.

Elijah challenged the priests of Baal on Mount Carmel because the people were trying to worship both Yahweh and Baal. Elijah told them they had to choose one or the other (1 Kings 18:21, 24). Amos gave a similar message.

When Amos came to Israel, shortly before 753 BC, the rich were becoming richer. The poor were becoming poorer. Around 801 BC, Assyria had captured

Damascus. But Assyria soon had to leave because of problems in other places. Egypt was also becoming weaker during this time. This left Israel and Judah with less pressure from powerful nations.

As a result, both kingdoms became stronger. They took back some land they had lost to Aram (2 Kings 14:23–29; 15:1–7; 2 Chronicles 26:1–23). Israel and Judah became more wealthy. But this wealth mostly helped the people who already had power. People with little power suffered even more.

Because of this, Amos traveled from Tekoa in Judah to Bethel, a place of worship in the northern kingdom. There he warned Israel about its apostasy (turning away from God) and its cruel treatment of people.

Summary

Amos told Israel that words alone are not enough in worship of the Lord. True worship must include faithful obedience.

After a short introduction (Amos 1:1–2), the first part of the book gives eight charges against sin (1:3–2:16). The first seven charges are against the nations around Israel. The eighth charge is against Israel itself. Amos first speaks against Israel’s enemies. He condemns their war crimes and their false worship. This helps his hearers agree with him.

Then Amos says, “The people of Israel, too, have sinned.” The next part of the book has three prophetic messages (3:1–5:17). A prophetic message is a message from God spoken through a prophet.

The first message says that Israel misused its special place as God’s chosen people (3:1–2). The second message accuses Israel’s wealthy people of living for pleasure while they hurt the poor (4:1–3). The third message is like a funeral song. It speaks of the coming death of the nation (5:1–2).

Between these messages, Amos uses many ways to call Israel back to God:

- He asks strong questions (3:3–6).
- He uses metaphors from his life as a shepherd (3:8, 12).
- He speaks with sharp irony, saying the opposite of what he means to show Israel’s sin (4:4–5).
- He reminds Israel of its past (4:6–11).
- He includes parts of songs that praise God (4:13; 5:8–9).
- He uses wordplay (5:5).
- He calls the people to repent.
- He also warns them about the judgment that will come if they refuse to repent.

The third part of Amos has two prophetic messages of woe (5:18–6:14). A message of woe warns people that judgment is coming. The first message warns people who talk about the day of the Lord as good news for Israel. They think God will make Israel strong again. But Amos says that day will bring judgment, not safety (5:18–27). The second message warns people who trust in their wealth, houses, or strong cities to save them (6:1–14).

The fourth part of the book includes five prophetic messages based on visions (7:1–9:10). A vision is something God shows a prophet. Amos first describes two judgments that God would stop (7:1–6). These visions may have helped his hearers listen to him. Then Amos gives two visions of judgments that God would not stop (7:7–9; 8:1–3). Between these visions, the book tells a short story from Amos's life (7:10–17). The final vision shows the complete destruction of Israel and its religious system (9:1–10).

Finally, Amos promises that better days will come (9:11–15). God will bring healing and restoration. Jerusalem will be rebuilt. David's royal line will be restored in the land. The people will live in the peace of God's kingdom.

Date and Location

Amos's ministry was short. It may have lasted only one year. He spoke at Bethel, the royal place of worship in the northern kingdom (Amos 7:13). This happened shortly before Jeroboam II died in 753 BC (1:1).

Recipients

Amos spoke to all the people of Israel. But he spoke especially to the rich and powerful people who lived for their own pleasure (see especially Amos 5:18–6:8). Amos saw Israel's split from Judah as a main reason for its moral and spiritual decline. Israel had separated from the temple in Jerusalem, the main place where God's people worshiped the Lord. But Amos also knew that Judah was turning away from pure worship of the Lord (2:4–5). So the book condemns "those at ease in Zion and those secure on Mount Samaria" (see 6:1).

The Prophet Amos

All we know about Amos's life comes from the book that bears his name. The opening words of the book say that he was a shepherd (Hebrew *noqed*). He came from Tekoa, now called Teku'a. Tekoa was a small, strong town about eight kilometers (five miles) south of Bethlehem in Judah.

Earlier scholars often described the prophet Amos as a poor shepherd who represented the lower classes in Judah. Wealthy landlords treated these people with injustice and abuse. More recent studies suggest a different view. The Hebrew word commonly used for a shepherd is *ro'eh* (as in Psalm 23:1), not *noqed*.

Outside the book of Amos, this word appears only in (2 Kings 3:4). There it describes Mesha, king of Moab. Mesha regularly gave Israel a large payment of wool and sheep. For this reason, *noqed* probably means someone who owned sheep. It may not mean a hired shepherd who worked for someone else.

Amos 7:14 gives another clue. Here Amos uses a different word for shepherd (*boqer*, literally "herder"). This might mean that Amos owned cattle. If so, he may have had a good amount of wealth.

Amos also describes himself as "a tender of sycamore-fig trees" (7:14). People used the fruit from these trees as food for animals. The Hebrew word used here is *boles* ("one who cares for sycamore figs"). This word does not appear anywhere else in the Bible. But because Amos also calls himself a *boqer*, the word may mean that he raised sycamore figs. It may not mean that he worked in orchards owned by other people.

This new view does not picture Amos as a simple herder who cared for another person's sheep and trees. Instead, Amos may have owned and managed animals and trees. This view also fits the book of Amos well. The book is written in strong Judean Hebrew. It also shows that Amos understood Israel's history, politics, and economy in his own time.

Meaning and Message

Moses showed that God is just and deeply cares for weak and poor people (see, for example, Deuteronomy 24:10–22). But Israel turned away from God and became morally corrupt. This allowed powerful people to oppress the poor and weak. The people wrongly began to see wealth as a sign that God approved of them. They cared more about how they looked than about true obedience. This went against God's call for his people to be holy.

True worship of the true God leads people to treat others rightly. But false worship and false beliefs damage human relationships. What people believe about God shapes how they live. Right worship leads to good works. Faith should lead to real change.

Morality is not only about personal purity or honesty. It also includes how we treat other people. This is because every human life is made by God and bears

his image (Genesis 1:26–27). We serve God by serving the people and creatures he has made.

Amos called people in every generation to treat weak and suffering people with care. For this reason, his words have inspired many social reformers. For example, Martin Luther King Jr. used Amos's warnings and calls to justice in his preaching. His preaching helped support the American civil rights movement in the 1950s and 1960s.